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SHOW OF UNITY
Himachal Pradesh CM Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu (centre) with Congress leaders Vikramaditya and Pratibha Singh in Shimla, July 13

HIMACHAL PRADESH

SUKHU COMES OUT STRONGER

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

In mountainous Himachal Pradesh, dark monsoon clouds may have resulted in torrential rains, but the political clouds surrounding the chair of Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu appear to have been dispelled for now. In the recent bypolls held in three seats on July 10—Dehra, Nalagarh and Hamirpur—the Congress won two, and increased its tally once again to 40 seats in the 68-member assembly. Kamlesh Thakur, Sukhu's wife, won from Dehra and Hardeep Singh Bawa won from Nalagarh for the Grand Old Party. The BJP managed to retain Hamirpur, with Ashish Sharma, the former independent MLA who joined the saffron party, holding on by 1,571 votes. The BJP's assembly numbers have risen to 28.

The bypolls had become necessary because three independent MLAs, Hoshiyar Singh (Dehra), Ashish Sharma and K.L. Thakur (Nalagarh)—all supporters of the Congress government—had shifted loyalties, voted for the BJP in the Rajya Sabha polls in late February and resigned thereafter. They all joined the BJP later. But they were only the outer eddies of the whirpool that had threatened to suck in the Sukhu regime. At its centre were six Congress MLAs who cross-voted for the BJP's Harsh Mahajan to defeat party candidate Abhishek Manu Singhvi. They were disqualified speedily and the Congress avenged itself by retaining four of those six seats, bypolls for which were held along with the Lok Sabha polls. Of the six rebel Congressmen, only Sudhir Sharma (Dharamshala) and Inder Dutt Lakhanpal (Barsar) could win back their seats on BJP tickets. What has come now is near-total recovery of honour.

The victory at Dehra is special for Sukhu as it marks the entry of his wife in politics. While the BJP argues that the CM deployed the entire government machinery to achieve victory, the Congress did benefit from internal feuds in the BJP. Notably, former CM Prem Kumar Dhamal has struck a critical note—saying he was not consulted in the entire February episode and that the BJP meddled in the Congress's affairs too soon.

The declaration of results for all nine bypolls brings a tame end to the Himachal edition of the BJP's 'Operation Lotus', which had aimed at toppling the fledgling Sukhu regime. The stock of his principal rival in the Himachal